find a way out of the Ukraine crisis so that Europe could “normalise” relations with Russia. Russia remains a major player in global energy: the largest gas supplier to Europe, OPEC’s partner in regulating global crude supplies, and influencing Central Asian and Caspian energy projects. Military intervention in Syria enabled it to regain influence in the Middle East. It is today the only country (other than India!) which has cordial relations with all countries in the region across political, religious, and sectarian divides. Every leader of the region has maintained personal contact with President Putin through visits and telephone calls, all documented on the Kremlin website.

Questions continue to be asked whether Russia has the domestic strength and internal resilience to sustain this external posture. Its economy does not match its great power ambitions, and efforts for its structural reform have often petered out. President Putin has recently launched an ambitious socioeconomic development programme to address economic, social, and demographic challenges. He has simultaneously initiated constitutional processes that would potentially enable him to serve two more terms, up to 2036. The precipitous fall in oil prices could affect the pace of socioeconomic reform. The handling of the ongoing health crisis caused by the COVID pandemic could impact President Putin’s popularity. Given the centralisation of power and policy in the Kremlin and the personal stamp of President Putin on virtually every major domestic and foreign policy decision in Russia since 2000, his political fate would have a major impact on how Russia’s military, political, and economic standing will develop, vis-à-vis China and the United States.

President Putin’s ambitious initiative for a Greater Eurasia, which could ward off Chinese hegemony, has to overcome asymmetry, history, and current geopolitical trends. The obvious asymmetry of the relationship belies Russia’s self-image as an equal partner. There are some cracks behind